

I did not experience any major issues accessing features, or anything else. So, Apple users, if you are looking for a pair of TWS earbuds on a budget, then you can definitely consider these. Lastly, the dual device quick switch also works like a charm, rounding off the user experience perfectly.

PERFORMANCE

The most important part of the review - the performance of the OnePlus Buds 3. These earbuds bring in a sound signature that must be familiar to the users of OnePlus' earbuds. The sound signature, as you can see, is U-shaped, which means that you get a bass-boosted sound, with the highs also getting a boost to balance things out.

In tracks like Uptown Funk by Bruno Mars, the bass response was punchy, and did not sound muddy, which is the case with many earbuds at this price. In the highs, because of the boost, there was a slight bit of sibilance that I could notice, but not much. For starters, sibilance in audio signifies the over-emphasis of the S and T sounds in the response of a pair of gear. In vocal-heavy tracks as well, there was not much to complain about, apart from sections where I did feel the drop off in clarity in the presence of a very complex mix of instruments. If you are listening to tracks by bands like Linkin Park, where certain tracks are backed by very dense instrument lines, then you will definitely experience a slight loss of clarity in the vocals.

What some brands do in this case is, have a dual driver setup, which divides the work of sound reproduction between two drivers, one for bass and one for mids and the highs. This also needs to be done with a lot of care, to avoid auditory masking. OnePlus has done that, and succeeded in almost all respects.

If you are to draw parallels between the sound signature of the OnePlus Buds 3 with another pair of TWS earbuds, the I would say, look at the Nothing Ear (2) and the Oppo Enco Air 3 Pro. The Oppo Enco Air 3 Pro performs an excellent balancing act, ensuring

that you get a well-rounded sound on a budget. The Nothing Ear (2) has the most prominent bass boost of the lot, and at times, does sound a bit off-place, with the bass sounding muddy. OnePlus Buds 3 is bang in the middle. Due to the lows and highs having a boost, it hits the right notes most of the time, but missed out on a few occasions.

As for the mic, I placed calls and took samples across a wide variety of scenarios. In noise heavy situations, for example, when you are walking on the road, the mic struggles to single out the voice of the speaker in some cases. However, for the most part, it works well. In silent rooms, you will have no



difficulty in making calls or recording audio. Same is with the ANC. In noisy situations where the sound coming in is erratic, there are a few shrill notes that are let in. However, for the most part, it gets the ANC basics right, thanks to the isolation that the buds offer, due to their excellent fit.

BATTERY LIFE

The battery life on the OnePlus Buds 3 is claimed to be 44 hours in total (ANC off, 50% volume, AAC). I tested these earbuds with ANC on, and volume set at 50 per cent and the buds clocked in 6 hours and 15 minutes, falling 15 minutes short of the claimed 6 hours and 30 minutes total. Impressive. As a reviewer, it was great to see OnePlus include different scenarios for battery-level claims that they made on their specs sheet. Most of the time, we are left wondering what the settings were, and in turn, you the reader are also left wondering where the deficit came in. If you run out of juice, you can quick charge these earbuds to get a claimed 7 hours of playback with just 10 minutes of charge. The charging

interface is USB-C and you get the signature OnePlus red and white cable in the box.

VERDICT

Having explained my opinions about the OnePlus Buds 3 in detail, I would like to sum up my review by giving these earbuds a two thumbs up. If you are someone looking for a pair of TWS earbuds that come with well-implemented features, a performance that suits most musical genres, ANC that works well for the price, and all that packed in a sleek and well built and looking package, then these earbuds are for you.

There are a few placed like the microphone and ANC in noisy environments, which could bother some, but with that out of the picture, you are looking at a solid contender in the ₹5,000 budget segment. OnePlus has implemented their learnings from their flagship earbuds, the OnePlus Buds Pro 2 and kept the light of hope about their core philosophy of making the best products for the lowest amount of money possible, alive. If you are looking for a unique aesthetic and are a fan of the Nothing sound signature, then they make for an excellent purchase as well, but factor in the extra money you will be spending on those earbuds. The Oppo Enco Air 3 Pro provide tough competition to the OnePlus Buds 3, and are definitely worth looking into.

—Satvik Pandey

SPECIFICATIONS

Dimensions: Earbuds: 3.168*2.022*2.44cm | Charging case: 5.872*5.015*2.581cm | Weight: Earbuds: 4.8g, Charging case: 40.8g | Drivers: 10.4mm woofer + 6mm tweeter dual drivers | Frequency Response: 15Hz-40KHz | Microphone Sensitivity: -38dB | Microphones: 3 mics per side | Rated Power: 10mW | Noise Cancellation: Up to 49dB Smart Adaptive Noise Cancellation | Frequency Range: 4kHz | Transparency Mode: Yes | Bluetooth Codec: LHDC/AAC/SBC | Bluetooth 5.3 | Transmission Protocol: HFP, A2DP, AVRCP | Google Fast Pair | Dual Connection | Water and Sweat Resistance: IP55

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